

Alcedo atthis

Common kingfisher



Length 6½ in (16 cm)
Weight 1¼ oz (35 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

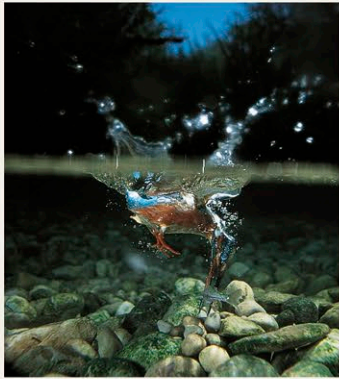
Location Europe, Asia, N. Africa



The common kingfisher is the only kingfisher encountered in most of Europe, where it is also known as the Eurasian kingfisher. It is a small, swift, and active bird with vivid, distinctive plumage. Size and coloration vary throughout its range, which stretches

from Western Europe and northern Africa through to East and Southeast Asia, and 7 subspecies are recognized. In the western sector of its range, it inhabits most aquatic habitats, but prefers lowland, freshwater streams or rivers. In eastern areas, it is more prevalent in coastal or subcoastal habitats, notably estuaries, mangroves, and intertidal pools. At high latitudes, freezing conditions force winter migration, although in warmer areas, birds move locally or are partially resident. Although it supplements its diet with crustaceans, amphibians, and insects, the common kingfisher primarily eats small fish, which it takes by plunge-diving. Each breeding pair occupies a territory of up to 2½ mile (1 km) along river banks. Pair-bonds are maintained through the breeding season, and both sexes incubate their eggs then care for the chicks for up to 4 weeks, until they are ready to leave the nest.

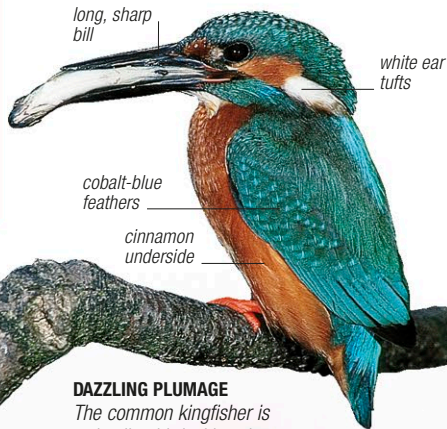
PLUNGE-DIVER



After a steep dive from a favored vantage perch or, less often, from hovering flight, the kingfisher catches its fish usually no deeper than 10 in (25 cm) below the water. Its natural buoyancy and a swift downstroke of its wings send it clear of the water's surface.

LIGHTNING STRIKE

Having captured its prey by a dramatic plunge-dive, the common kingfisher then takes it back to its perch, on which it strikes the fish repeatedly before swallowing it headfirst. Any undigested remains are usually regurgitated as pellets.



DAZZLING PLUMAGE

The common kingfisher is a dazzling bird with a deep cinnamon underside, greenish blue crown, back, and wings, and dazzling cobalt-blue rump and tail. Its sharp bill is well adapted for striking and grasping fish.



COURTING COUPLE

Courtship behavior is elaborate and includes erratic twisting and turning flights, as well as courtship feeding in which the kingfishers offer each other fish just before copulation.